professionalism, secularism and an apolitical approach, have resulted in our gaining the respect and trust of the people. The Indian Army has played a vital role in disaster management and often without waiting for orders. The army has a diversity that in many ways represents a microcosm of India. It is seen as an impartial organization which deals with a situation on its merits, without any extraneous considerations. The moment people in a strife-torn area see men in olive green, their confidence automatically gets restored.

The contribution of the armed forces in hastening the decision of the British to give India independence is an aspect on which adequate research has not been done. Certain unorchestrated actions by units, officers and men of the armed forces indicated solidarity with the civil disobedience and freedom movements. The 1857 revolt had never really been obliterated from the British psyche. 'Wavell had noted in his *Journal* that Churchill had "the impression that the Indian Army was liable to rise at any moment; and he accused me [Wavell] of creating a Frankenstein by putting modern weapons in the hands of sepoys,"[2] alluding to 1857.' The rebellion of 1857 'began as the mutiny of the Bengal Army, and was the defining moment for Indian Nationalism and can rightly be said to be the event that gave birth to an Indian national identity'.[3]

While the role of the army in war is well understood, in peace time it trains for war, a fact that is not well understood. The very existence of a disciplined, well-trained and potent military force deters potential adversaries, thus contributing to peace and stability. What do the armed forces expect in return? Only the respect and gratitude of a nation that recognizes and acknowledges the army's sacrifices. Dignity and honour are our prized possessions. When the soldier goes on leave he expects to be given a modicum of respect, especially while interacting with various civil authorities, and not be made to run from pillar to post for even the most mundane issues. There should be judicial and administrative edicts to ensure that his home and hearth is protected, and his family is not harassed while he is away guarding the borders or fighting terrorists. Sadly, that is not generally the case. I am reminded of the inscription on